

Chapter 175-1

The mountaintop.

The dim yellow setting sun had completely disappeared behind the mountain. The verdant hills held a few traces of spring vitality. Huichang Temple's incense was flourishing, and visitors still came and went in an endless stream, though most were heading down the mountain.

The entrance to the three thousand steps was desolate and deserted compared to the cable car entrance.

Dusk closed in on all sides. The lights of the entire city lit up in an instant. Scattered points of light dotted the base of the mountain, and with a casual glance, one could see the tallest building in the city.

Shen Siyan stood firmly behind Shen Hui, while Shen Hui stood with her back to the streetlamp, hands in her pockets, her silhouette lonely and desolate.

Before long, Shen Hui walked toward the three thousand steps.

"Second Sister." Shen Siyan called out from behind her. "Where are you going?"

Shen Hui didn't even turn her head: "To atone."

Shen Hui walked down with unwavering determination, her white sneakers quickly becoming covered in dust.

Shen Siyan didn't dare to pass her, and even less did he dare to stop her. He could only silently follow behind.

There were only the two of them on this path. They could hear the sound of wind blowing through the treetops—lively yet lonely.

Perhaps all paths in this world are the same—difficult and rough.

But there are thousands upon thousands of ways to walk them.

Shen Hui didn't know what kind of feelings she was walking down the three thousand steps with. She only knew that each step she took was heavy.

She didn't know how long she walked. In any case, several streetlamps around them had broken down, leaving the path too dark to see.

Shen Siyan turned on his flashlight behind her, illuminating the path ahead.

It wasn't until she heard the sound of knees hitting the ground, and the sound of a head heavily striking the stone steps, that she stopped.

She and Zhao Xuning were separated by more than a dozen stone steps. But Zhao Xuning seemed not to see her, only focusing on the next step ahead.

Zhao Xuning's expression was cold as always. Her whole body was dirty. She had already bundled up her white coat and tossed it to Liang Shi beside her. Two buttons of her white shirt were undone, and her sleeves were rolled up. Her complexion was pale, large beads of sweat dripping from her forehead, her lips without a trace of color.

This was probably the first time Shen Hui had seen such a wretched Zhao Xuning.

Far from the one in her memory.

Even back when she had a car accident and miscarriage, Zhao Xuning had only gotten red eyes at her bedside.

Later, when arguing with her sister at the hospital, she had only shouted hoarsely a few times.

She had never imagined she would one day see Zhao Xuning like this.

It was originally just words spoken in anger. Years of accumulated resentment had burst out when she came running over.

But she never expected that Zhao Xuning would actually do it.

She said she would kneel her way up the three thousand steps, and so it was one step, one bow—not a single step could be faked.

This was Zhao Xuning.

The resilient Zhao Xuning.

Shen Hui stood in place, her vision blurring. Shen Siyan handed her a tissue, but Shen Hui instinctively turned away, raising her hand to wipe away her tears. "Got sand in my eyes."

But there was no wind now.

The spring breeze had understood the mood and stopped blowing.

Adding warmth to this cold night.

But even without the spring breeze, what was meant to be chaotic would still be chaotic.

Such as one's heart and mind.

Shen Hui closed her eyes briefly, then walked toward Zhao Xuning with firm steps. Just as Zhao Xuning was about to kneel, she reached out and caught her, her slender body supporting all of Zhao Xuning's weight.

Zhao Xuning looked up. Seeing it was her, she smiled lightly, but the movement of her lips made her gasp in pain.

Zhao Xuning's voice was hoarse: "Why did you come?"

"Do you still want to continue up?" Shen Hui asked.

Zhao Xuning nodded: "I promised you."

"You can break the promise," Shen Hui said. "I'm not getting engaged anymore."

Zhao Xuning stared at her for a while and smiled lightly. "Why are you crying again?"

Shen Hui opened her mouth but didn't know what to say for a moment.

Zhao Xuning took out a handkerchief from her shirt pocket and handed it to her: "My hands are dirty. Wipe it yourself."

Shen Hui exhaled softly: "Didn't you say you'd rather die than kneel up the three thousand steps?"

"People can change." Zhao Xuning raised her hand to check her watch. "Already at one thousand seven hundred and eighty-nine. Still nine hundred and ninety-nine to go."

As she spoke, she turned her face and started coughing, coughing until her face turned red—which actually added some color to it.

Liang Shi immediately handed over water.

There were two gray marks at Zhao Xuning's knees, looking like they were about to wear through.

"Then have you changed?" Shen Hui asked.

Zhao Xuning nodded: "Mm."

She looked up at the path ahead, unable to see the end.

Shen Hui said: "You've achieved your goal. You don't need to kneel anymore."

"Going soft again." Zhao Xuning said with a smile, her tone intimate. "Didn't you say you were going to get revenge on me?"

Shen Hui pressed her lips together: "I've already gotten my revenge."

"But I haven't reached the top yet." Zhao Xuning smiled. "If I promised you, I have to do it."

Shen Hui's voice choked: "Are there few things you promised me but didn't do?"

"Which ones?" Zhao Xuning asked back.

"Junior year, you said we would go watch the sunrise together." Shen Hui sniffled and really did recount them one by one.

"Senior year, you said you would help me lose weight down to a hundred jin.¹ That same year, you promised to fold a thousand paper cranes for me. The first year abroad, you said you would knit me a scarf..." Shen Hui looked at her. "Should I continue?"

"Mm?" Zhao Xuning lightly licked her cracked lips.

Shen Hui gently closed her eyes, tears falling: "The last one—you said you would walk with me to the end and never break up."

"So, I'm still working on it." Zhao Xuning still smiled lightly, her eyes reddened. "The day we were supposed to watch the sunrise, you were on your period. Your stomach hurt so much you didn't fall asleep until two. I didn't wake you."

"You clearly loved eating so much. I just wanted to see you do what you love, so I kept buying you food. But I was the one who lost weight."

"The paper cranes I folded—you hugged them like a trash can and threw up on them when you were drunk. They were all ruined and thrown in the garbage."

"The scarf I knitted for you... was too ugly. I put it at the bottom of the closet. You didn't take it when you went abroad, and you never saw it."

Zhao Xuning spoke weakly, but still forced herself to continue.

She looked up at Shen Hui and blinked. "A-Hui, just the last one... I'm still trying."

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1. Jin (斤) is a Chinese unit of weight. One jin equals 500 grams or about 1.1 pounds. So "a hundred jin" is approximately 50 kg or 110 pounds. ⇐